

A Short History of Weaving

Weaving may be the oldest technology still in daily use. Long before metal, before the wheel, before writing, people discovered that two sets of thread – one held taut, one passed across it – could become something neither was alone: a surface, a garment, a sail, a story.

The principle has not changed in twenty thousand years. The warp runs lengthwise, strong and patient. The weft travels back and forth across it, one pass at a time. Every textile you have ever touched is a negotiation between these two directions – structure and movement, the long thread and the crossing one.

What changed was everything around the principle. The loom began as a branch and a row of stone weights. It became the frame loom, then the treadle loom, then the great mechanical looms of the industrial age. In 1804, Joseph-Marie Jacquard attached punched cards to a loom so that it could weave patterns too intricate for human memory. Those cards – presence and absence, hole and no hole – carried instructions the machine could read. A century and a half later, the same idea would run the first computers. It is only a small exaggeration to say that software was born on a loom.

Weaving also gave us our words for thinking together. We lose the thread of an argument and pick it up again. Stories are spun; plots are woven; ideas hang together on the slenderest of threads. A text and a textile are the same Latin word – *texere*, to weave.

This document is here so you can hear it read aloud. Somewhere as you listen, a model is turning these sentences into sound a few hundred characters at a time, each passage woven into the audio stream as it is made – the weft, as ever, crossing the warp one pass at a time.